SPECIMEN

A Rare-Plant Collector Economy — Business Plan & Build Plan

Prepared: 24 October 2026 | Status: Draft for review | Version 2 (fact-checked & corrected)

The one-line pitch

A free-to-play, global, asynchronous rare-plant collector economy: care for real houseplants, open blind-box "pots" to reveal species and variegations, complete collection albums, bid in time-limited live auctions, and challenge rivals through shareable cards. The real-world rare-houseplant market already runs as a collector economy — rarity tiers, blind reveals, live auctions, limited drops, trading, price anchors. Every game that touched plants built farming or shop-management instead. That gap is the product.

1. Executive Summary

Element	Summary
The product	SPECIMEN — a collectible rare-plant economy sim: care, reveal, collect, compete, trade, auction.
Why now	Life sim is the fastest-growing sim subgenre (+76% YoY); Heartopia proved the ceiling; collection-album LiveOps is the hottest midcore mechanic; blind-box reveal and auction formats are proven revenue engines; rare houseplants are a certified real-world collectibles trend.
The gap	The real world already trades rare plants at auction with rarity tiers. No game has modelled that economy. Existing plant games are grow-and-sell or grow-and-merge.
Monetisation	Blind-box reveals, live auction drops, album completion, cosmetics, convenience packs, event passes, rewarded video, plus an unclaimed line in real plant-brand partnerships.
Revenue scenarios	Conservative $0.3–1.5M/yr · Base $4–12M/yr · Breakout $20–60M+/yr.
Build	Web-first PWA plus app stores. 12–16 weeks to v1. Team of 2–3.
Top risks	Gacha regulation · review-bombing over AI art and gacha fairness (Heartopia's lesson) · care "chore fatigue" · crowded adjacent indie space.

2. The Product

2.1 Core loop

One thumb, 1–3 minute sessions. Six steps, one repeating cycle:

Step	What the player does	Why it exists
Care	Tap to water, feed, rotate. Plants grow in real time.	Daily-login habit loop. Never a punishment — plants do not die.
Reveal	Buy a sealed pot (blind box), break it open, get species + variegation roll.	The dopamine hit. ASMR sound + particles. This is the session.
Complete	Fill the collection album (species x variegation x trait).	Retention engine. Completing a genus grants permanent bonuses.
Compete	Leaderboards + rival challenge cards ("My Thai Constellation hit 98% health — beat it").	Virality + retention. Card is deep-linkable and shareable.
Trade	Gift cuttings, visit gardens, trade duplicates.	Social surface. Low-pressure async, no simultaneous play required.
Auction	Time-limited global live drops. Bid premium currency on a rare cultivar.	FOMO engine, event cadence, whale magnet.

2.2 Meta progression

Garden room -> shelves -> terrarium -> greenhouse -> rare-specimen vault. Each tier adds collection slots and raises the rarity ceiling. Progression is cosmetic and convenience-based, deliberately avoiding pay-to-win.

2.3 Differentiators

- African Specimens collection category — rare Euphorbia, Pachypodium, Aloe polyphylla, African violets, West-African plant-market aesthetic. Under-served, globally legible, and content no US/EU/Chinese studio will think to build.
- Real-world rarity anchoring — species value and scarcity are modelled on actual collector market data, which is free content and an educational hook.
- Lightweight by design — loads fast and runs on low-end hardware, a genuine advantage in Africa, SEA and LatAm where AAA-size installs fail.
- Asynchronous only — no simultaneous-server requirement, which keeps infrastructure cost low and matchmaking complexity at zero.

3. Market Opportunity

IMPORTANT — data-quality note: every figure below is a third-party estimate. Trackers disagree by 2–3x for the same game, and several widely-quoted numbers in this space are outliers or company self-reports. Ranges are given where estimates diverge. See Section 9 for the full correction list.

3.1 The genre is winning

Signal	Figure	Source / caveat
Life Sim revenue, H1 2026	$118M, +76% YoY (downloads +30%)	AppMagic (now Sensor Tower SMB). Fastest-growing tracked sim subgenre.
Farming revenue, H1 2026	$576M, +15% YoY	AppMagic. Established backbone of the sim category.
Simulation genre, 2025/26	$5.2–6.1B, ~+12% YoY	Two independent trackers; range reflects methodology differences.
Hybrid-casual IAP	$4.2B in 2025, +20%; top-10 titles +67–100% YoY	Sensor Tower / Game World Observer. The standout growth engine of casual.

3.2 One game proved the ceiling

Heartopia (XD) — a cozy multiplayer life sim with hobbies, avatar, home-building and cosmetic gacha — launched globally on 7 January 2026 (Steam 16 January). It became the top free mobile game in 50+ countries per its publisher, and its official site claims 30M+ downloads. A reported (unverified) figure of >$20M revenue in February 2026 circulated on social media; no authoritative tracker confirms it. On Steam it holds roughly 66% positive across ~16,100 reviews — a "Mixed" rating, down from "Mostly Positive" at launch. See Section 9 for what actually drove that decline, because it is the single most useful lesson in this plan.

3.3 The collection-album mechanic is the current midcore favourite

- Clash of Clans — "Clash of Cards" 14th-anniversary collectible album (2026), with a clan-member trade layer.
- PUBG Mobile — Card Collection with themed sets, draws and exchanges (2026).
- CSR Racing 2 — "The Circuit" card collection event (July 2026).

- CookieRun: Card Collection — Roblox, collect/customise/trade, launched 10 October 2026.
- Analyst read: "collectible album games… are becoming a key element of LiveOps" in midcore.
- Gossip Harbor runs an estimated 20–100 live events per month — the cadence benchmark.

3.4 Reveal and auction formats are proven money

Format	Evidence	Caveat
Blind-box / unboxing	Estimated $13.5–20.5B market; unboxing clips are the marketing engine for Labubu/Pop Mart.	Range is a blog aggregation of several research firms, not a single audited figure.
Gacha draws	$27.9B (2025) -> $38.0B (2034), CAGR 3.5%.	Excludes ads, premium sales and physical blind boxes.
Collectible card games	Pokémon TCG Pocket grew +209% to $867.3M in H1 2026.	Strong proof for card-collection monetisation at scale.
Auction format	Free Fire runs an "ultra-whale auction format with serialized skins and a refund mechanism".	Confirms auctions as a shipping top-10 mechanic, not an experiment.

3.5 The subject is a real, live, traded market

Garden Media Group's 2026 Garden Trends Report names rare houseplants as a must-have collectible of 2026. Note that Garden Media Group is a PR and marketing agency, so its trend framing is partly promotional — treat it as a directional signal, not an independent measurement.

The indoor plants market is large but the numbers vary a lot by definition: the main research firms put it at roughly $12.4–14.6B for 2026 growing ~4% CAGR, while more aggressive firms publish $20–25B. The correct positioning is: a large, slow-growing base market, with rare-plant collecting as a small, high-margin, fast-growing collectibles niche sitting on top of it.

More relevant than market size is the fact that this is a live commerce market with genuine price discovery — the mechanics the game needs already exist in the real world:

- Rare plants are the largest live-shopping category on Palmstreet, per Palmstreet's own head of brand marketing (a company claim).
- A single variegated Anthurium sold for $26,000 on Palmstreet, with two further plants sold the same day for $16,000 — reported by Forbes.
- Palmstreet estimates ~100 million plants will be purchased on the platform this year (company estimate).
- A TikTok Shop plant seller moves roughly 5,000 plants per week and tripled income in early 2026 by converting livestreams into auctions — a single-person anecdote, not a market statistic.

4. Competitive Landscape

4.1 What already exists

Game	What it is	Relevant limitation
Leafy Corner	Cozy plant-shop management. ~57K Steam copies / ~$455K estimated (medium confidence, Steam-only); also on Switch/PS5/Xbox. ~96–97% positive.	Premium, single-player, shop keeper. Player base declining on Steam (Sept 2026 ~-59% MoM).
Plant Nursery Simulator	Nursery management with crops, stocking, staff.	Shop management, indie scale.
Plant Therapy	F2P plant collecting and decorating, 649 reviews, ~97% positive (2023).	Premium-DLC model; no reveals, auctions or live drops.
Pocket Plants	Merge-and-grow plant collection, 100s of plants, step-tracker tie-in.	Merge mechanic; no auction economy.

Game	What it is	Relevant limitation
Terrarium: Garden Idle	Idle plant collection and expansion.	Idle only; thin social surface.
Growden.io	Multiplayer garden .io game; trade seeds, weekly growing contests.	Closest competitor on social. Still grow-and-trade, no reveals or auctions.
The Cozy Florist	Flower-shop sim with garden visits, trades and a flower-stealing mechanic.	Flowers, not rare houseplants; shop sim.
Strange Horticulture	Narrative plant-shop puzzle game (2022).	Story-driven, niche, single-player.

4.2 What does not exist

- No plant game combines blind-box rare-variegation reveals with a live auction economy.
- No plant game uses real-world rarity and price anchors as its core balance layer.
- No plant game runs time-limited global drops as its primary event mechanic.
- No plant game ships as a lightweight, global, free-to-play web/PWA product with collection-album LiveOps.

Precision matters here: the subject (plants) is crowded at indie level. The mechanic (collectible reveal + auction economy + album LiveOps) is not. This plan is written around the mechanic, not the subject.

5. Business Model

Lever	Pattern	Reference
Blind-box reveals	Sealed pot purchase with rarity roll	Heartopia, Pokémon TCG Pocket — $27.9B gacha market
Live auction drops	Time-limited global bidding	Free Fire whale auction; Palmstreet plant auctions
Album completion	Card set collection bonuses	Clash of Cards, PUBG Card Collection, CSR2
Cosmetic pots / garden rooms	Avatar and space cosmetics	Heartopia, MONOPOLY GO!
Convenience packs	Care-speed, fertiliser, vault slots	Hybrid-casual standard
Event / season pass	Pass monetisation	MONOPOLY GO!, Hay Day
Rewarded video	Free reveals for ad views	Hybrid IAA+IAP default
Real plant-brand deals	Digital twin of a real rare plant; nursery-sponsored drops	Palmstreet / TikTok Shop live commerce — unclaimed in games

5.1 The brand-deal line is real and unclaimed

Rare-plant live commerce already operates at scale ($26,000 single plant; ~100M plants/yr per Palmstreet's own estimate). A "buy this real rare plant, receive its digital specimen" offer, or a nursery-sponsored auction drop, converts the game's own cultural trend into a second revenue stream that no game studio currently owns.

5.2 Revenue scenarios

Anchored on hybrid-casual IAP of $4.2B and growing (top-10 titles +67–100% YoY), All in Hole at $200M+ since 2024, and Gossip Harbor at a record ~$112M IAP in August 2026.

Scenario	Assumption	Estimated annual revenue
Conservative	30–80K DAU, ~$0.03–0.06 IAP per DAU	$0.3–1.5M
Base	Breakout hybrid-casual, 300–800K DAU	$4–12M
Breakout	Top-grosser mechanics executed at scale	$20–60M+

5.3 Cost and margin notes

- Server-authoritative rolls and signed results mean the client cannot fake a pull — the same trust model used for competitive result settlement.
- Content cost is low: plants are procedurally generatable (leaf shape x colour x variegation pattern x pot), so 100+ species ship in weeks.
- Asynchronous-only architecture keeps live-ops costs proportional to event count, not to concurrent players.
- Regulatory compliance (odds disclosure, no cash-out, no gambling framing) should be treated as a product feature, not a legal afterthought.

6. Go-to-Market

1. Ship MVP to web/PWA first, then app stores. Web-first is the cheapest path to a global audience and the fastest feedback loop.
2. Seed TikTok, Reels and YouTube Shorts with reveal clips. The reveal is the marketing unit; short-form is where Mystery Dumpling scaled.
3. Weekly live drops from week one — the cadence is the retention strategy, modelled on Gossip Harbor's 20–100 events per month.
4. Rival challenge cards as the growth loop: every session generates a shareable, deep-linkable challenge.
5. Plant-creator and plantfluencer collaborations rather than generic influencer buys — the audience already exists and already buys.
6. First brand partnership (nursery, plant brand, or live-commerce platform) targeted for the 60–90 day window.

7. Risk Register

Risk	Severity	Mitigation
Gacha / blind-box regulation spreading (Singapore began regulating blind boxes and card packs in Feb 2026)	High	Published odds, no real-money cash-out, no gambling framing, no loot-box labelling. Structure the purchase as buying a specific sealed pot.
Review-bombing over AI art — Heartopia was bullied into disclosing undisclosed generative-AI artwork and its rating fell from "Mostly Positive" to "Mixed"	High	Disclose AI usage from day one. Do not ship undisclosed AI-generated art.
Review-bombing over gacha fairness — Heartopia's negatives also cited a gacha system "that felt more aggressive than cozy"	High	Design the reveal as a generous, transparent, collection-first system. Avoid pity-timer exploitation.
Chore fatigue — watering timers read as a job (FarmVille fatigue)	Medium	Plants never die, generous offline progress, care is optional optimization, the session is the reveal.
Crowded adjacent space — 20+ plant games exist	Medium	Differentiate on mechanic (reveal + auction + album), not subject. Track Leafy Corner's decline as evidence the form matters.
Subject-vs-market mismatch — the indoor plants base market grows only ~4% CAGR	Medium	Position as a collectibles game riding the rare-plant collectibles trend, not a gardening game.
Low IAP in unboxing games — the breakout unboxing title is ad-driven, not IAP-driven	Medium	Use reveal for acquisition (ads), use album completion and auctions for monetisation. Never rely on the reveal itself to monetise.

Risk	Severity	Mitigation
Content volume / art pipeline	Medium	Procedural plant generation plus real species data. Ship 100+ species cheaply and expand by category.
Platform policy on randomised rewards	Medium	Region-by-region review of store policy; pre-build alternate purchase flows where required.

8. Build Plan

8.1 Recommended stack

Layer	Recommendation	Why
Game client	HTML5 Canvas (2D) or WebGL, TypeScript	Procedural plant rendering, instant web launch, lowest art cost.
App distribution	PWA + Capacitor / TWA for store builds	One codebase, web-first launch, store listings later.
Backend	Node.js (or Bun) service, server-authoritative economy	Signed rolls, signed results, simple to operate.
Data	PostgreSQL for state; Redis for sessions and leaderboards	Predictable scale for async-only play.
Delivery	CDN + static hosting; CI with automated tests	Low latency globally; repeatable releases.

8.2 Phases and milestones

Phase	Duration	Deliverables	Exit criteria
0 — Validation spike	Weeks 1–2	Clickable reveal prototype; 3 plants, 1 pot, 1 sound. Run a 50-person test.	Reveal is satisfying; >60% want "one more".
1 — Core loop	Weeks 3–6	Care state machine, real-time growth, garden grid, procedural renderer, local persistence.	Full care->grow->reveal loop playable offline.
2 — Economy	Weeks 7–10	Collection schema, server-authoritative blind-box rolls, reveal animation and audio, album completion.	Rolls are tamper-proof; albums grant bonuses.
3 — Social & LiveOps	Weeks 11–14	Leaderboards, rival challenge cards, async gift/visit, first live auction drop, event pass.	A challenge card can be sent and accepted end-to-end.
4 — Launch	Weeks 15–16	Share-card generator, analytics, store submissions, launch content pack.	v1 shipped to web and app stores.
5 — Scale	Weeks 17+	African Specimens category, second collection category, weekly drops, first brand deal.	D1 retention >40%, reveal-to-share >5%.

8.3 Scope discipline — cut for v1

- Full trading UI — ship gifting only; trade layer is phase 2.
- Persistent auction house — ship time-limited drops only.
- Real-time co-op — never. Asynchronous only, by design.
- African Specimens category — hold as the first post-launch content pack, so v1 ships on time.
- Discover/exploration tracks — later; they need a content pipeline you do not have yet.

8.4 Team and budget

Role	Allocation	Notes
Lead programmer (gameplay, economy, backend)	Full-time	Procedural rendering and server-authoritative rolls are the critical path.

Role	Allocation	Notes
Programmer (client/UI/live-ops tooling)	Full-time	Album, drops, cards, analytics.
Art / audio (part-time or contractor)	Part-time	Reveal polish and ASMR audio are the product; do not under-fund them.
Live-ops / community	Part-time from launch	Weekly drops are the retention strategy; someone must own the calendar.

Budget: mostly personnel. Infrastructure is small while asynchronous-only. The largest non-personnel cost is short-form video seeding and the reveal audio/art polish — both should be prioritised over additional features.

9. Corrections — Errors and Misinformation Found in Pressure-Testing

The following items were checked and corrected. They are documented because they change decisions, and because the same errors are easy to repeat.

Item	Previous claim	Corrected position
Heartopia Steam rating cause	Attributed to install size / mobile-first design.	It is ~66% positive, "Mixed" (~16,100 reviews), down from "Mostly Positive" at launch. The drivers were undisclosed generative-AI artwork (players bullied the studio into disclosure), complaints that the gacha felt more aggressive than cozy, and poor PC controls — not install size.
Heartopia downloads	Stated as 5M+.	5M+ was third-party mobile reporting at launch; the official site claims 30M+ worldwide. Both can be true at different times. Cite the source and the date.
Heartopia revenue	Stated as >$20M in February 2026.	This is a reported social-media figure, not a tracker-confirmed number. Third-party estimates vary widely. Present as unverified.
Indoor plants market size	Stated as ~$21B.	Overstated. Major firms put 2026 at roughly $12.4–14.6B growing ~4% CAGR; $20–25B figures come from more aggressive firms. Use the range and the caveat.
Gossip Harbor, Aug 2026	Stated as $160M.	IAP-only estimates are ~$105–112M for a record month (AppMagic $112.3M; Attn Economy/Sensor Tower $111M; Appfigures $105M). The $160M figure likely includes ads and web-shop revenue.
Mystery Dumpling monetisation	Cited as an IAP success.	It is ad-driven. Google Play shows 10M+ installs and ~$2 of IAP per user. It proves the virality of the unboxing reveal, not its monetisation.
Mystery Dumpling downloads	Stated as 9M.	AppMagic reported 9M in August; other sources say 11M in the launch month; Google Play now shows 10M+. Use the range.
Hybrid-casual "only growing segment"	Stated as the only casual segment growing.	Overstated. Hybrid-casual is the standout growth engine and the only segment growing IAP revenue in Sensor Tower's framing — but several subgenres also grew (merge-2 +74%, life sim +76%, farming +15%).
"Nobody has built this"	Stated flatly.	The subject is crowded at indie level. The precise claim is that no game combines blind-box reveals, a live auction economy, album LiveOps and real-world rarity anchoring.
Palmstreet claims	Presented as fact.	"Largest live-shopping category" and "~100M plants this year" are company self-reports. The $26,000 Anthurium sale is reported by Forbes.
Garden Media Group trend	Presented as fact.	Garden Media Group is a PR/marketing agency; its trend framing is partly promotional. Use as directional signal only.

Item	Previous claim	Corrected position
Leafy Corner figures	Stated as $455K and -59%.	Raijin estimate, medium confidence, Steam-only. The game also launched on Switch, PS5 and Xbox, so total revenue is higher. The -59% is Steam average daily players for Sept 2026 (partial month).
Tracker reliability	Not flagged.	Sensor Tower acquired AppMagic in May 2026. Independent estimates for the same app routinely differ by 2–3x. All figures here are directional, not audited.

10. KPIs and Kill Criteria

Metric	Target	If missed
D1 retention	>40%	The care loop is a chore. Fix reveal pacing and session length — do not change the subject.
D7 retention	>18%	The collection is not compelling. Widen the album, add a second rarity axis.
Reveal-to-share rate	>5%	The reveal is not satisfying or not legible. Rework the animation and share card.
IAP conversion	>2% of DAU	The paid proposition is unclear. Re-price packs; lead with collection completion.
DAU/MAU at day 60	>25%	Live-ops cadence is wrong. Increase drop frequency and reduce overlap.
Auction drop participation	>20% of active players	The drop is not compelling. Add scarcity and visible bidding.

11. Backup Ideas (if the plant thesis is rejected)

Idea	Why it works	Main weakness
Rare "morph" creature breeder (reptile / fish / amphibian morphs)	Real morph market with real prices; genetics gives a deep completion loop; large global collector communities.	Narrower mass appeal; higher animal-welfare sensitivity.
Backyard birdwatching sim	Real species, rare migratory reveals, eBird/Audubon-style checklists, conservation partnerships. Genuinely under-served.	Monetisation depth is weaker; patience-based gameplay risks boredom.
Influencer / creator life sim	Very Gen-Z, very shareable, rides the creator economy.	Retention and monetisation unproven; the theme ages quickly.

12. Sources

Third-party estimates throughout. Directionally useful; not audited. Listed in the order they are used.

- AppMagic, Casual Games Report H1 2026 — life sim $118M / +76% YoY; farming $576M / +15% YoY; hybrid-casual IAP +20% to $4.2B; top-10 titles +67–100% YoY.
- AppMagic, "Everything Is a Simulator: Steam's Hottest 2026 Trend" — niche sim revenue benchmarks.
- Gamerant, Heartopia revenue report (Feb 2026) — reported >$20M in one month (unverified).
- Steam store page and SteamDB, Heartopia — ~66% positive, "Mixed", ~16,100 reviews; released 16 Jan 2026.
- Kotaku / GamingBible / PCGamesN (Jan 2026) — Heartopia undisclosed AI art controversy and rating decline.

- Notebookcheck (17 Jan 2026) — Heartopia early Steam peak and rating context.
- GamesPress / XD — Heartopia launch: top free mobile game in 50+ countries; seven core hobbies; My Little Pony collaboration.
- AppMagic, TikTok trends — Mystery Dumpling: Unbox ASMR, 9M downloads in August 2026, 13M total.
- Google Play / AppBrain, Mystery Dumpling — 10M+ installs, ~$2 IAP per user (ad-driven).
- AppMagic / MobileGamer.biz / Appfigures (Sept–Oct 2026) — Gossip Harbor August 2026 IAP estimates ($105–112M).
- PocketGamer.biz, Top 50 Mobile Game Makers of 2026 — All in Hole $200M+; Gossip Harbor $160M (likely includes ads/web shop); Gossip Harbor $2B lifetime IAP.
- AppMagic, Gossip Harbor LiveOps — 20 to 100 events per month; $720M cumulative IAP as of Dec 2025.
- Singular, Top mobile games 2026 — Gossip Harbor $1.32B H1 2026, +468%; Pokémon TCG Pocket $867.3M, +209%.
- Dataintelo, Global Gacha Games Market — $27.9B (2025) to $38.0B (2034); Singapore blind-box regulation Feb 2026.
- Watcooks, blind boxes 2026 — $13.5–20.5B market range (blog aggregation of research firms).
- GameRefinery, Mobile Game Market Review (May / Jul–Aug 2026) — Free Fire whale auction; card album LiveOps trend; exploration tracks.
- GameRefinery, Mobile Game Market Review (March 2026) — PUBG Mobile Card Collection.
- Forbes (6 Nov 2025) — $26,000 Anthurium on Palmstreet; rare plants the largest live-shopping category; ~100M plants/yr estimate.
- People (23 Oct 2026) — TikTok Shop rare-plant livestream auctions (single-seller anecdote).
- Homes & Gardens / Garden Insider (2026) — Garden Media Group 2026 Garden Trends Report: collectible houseplants.
- Mordor Intelligence / Fortune Business Insights / Business Research Insights / Research and Markets / Global Growth Insights (2026) — indoor plants market $12.4–14.6B, ~4% CAGR.
- Custom Market Insights / Market.us (2026) — higher outliers: $20–25B.
- Terrarium Tribe / Amra & Alma (2026) — houseplant statistics roundups; 66% US household ownership.
- Raijin.gg — Leafy Corner Steam estimates (~57K copies, ~$455K, medium confidence).
- GamesIndustry.biz (13 May 2026) — Sensor Tower acquires AppMagic.
- Reddit r/ValkoHQ (Aug 2026) — explanation of why Sensor Tower, AppMagic and Qimai revenue estimates differ by 2–3x.

Note: revenue and download figures from app-intelligence vendors are modelled estimates built from panels, rankings and partial data. They are useful for ranking and for directional scenarios, and unreliable for precise attribution. Treat every number in this plan as an estimate with an error bar.